eliminate the group over time' and it is clear that Rakhine politicians are aiming at the forced removal of the Rohingyas from the country of their birth.[7]

That said, crimes by a state against its entire people (such as those of the Khmer Rouge in Cambodia) are not genocide, even if they are clearly a major breach of human rights and can be tried under other UN laws.[8] A definition of genocide requires a clear targeting of a defined group, in a manner that can include systemic persecution and exclusion. This is the case in Myanmar today. Equally, those who incite or are complicit in such crimes are judged to be as guilty as those who actually carry out the crime. This speaks directly to those Buddhist monks who claim that they bear no responsibility if others commit violence, having been inspired to so by what they say.

Recent scholarship has indicated that there are seven characteristics that will determine if a given instance of ethnic tension is likely to turn into an act of genocide.[9] These are:

- Previous instances of severe ethnic tension;
- Political upheaval;
- The governing elite is drawn overwhelmingly or entirely from a particular ethnic group;
- That elite has an ideology that believes it is right to persecute a particular ethnic group;
- The regime is autocratic;
- The regime is closed to the wider international order;
- A minority is targeted for severe political or economic discrimination.

The simple reality is that all these apply in Rakhine, even if there has been some opening up to the outside world in recent years. Furthermore, genocide is never the first step, but always follows from less severe forms of repression. The usual precursor is the creation of a racist culture that rationalises or encourages discrimination, systemic legal discrimination, and abuse of the historical record to construct a narrative in which mass murder becomes desirable or even imperative. The world has often failed when faced with incipient genocides,[10] sometimes because of the context of a wider conflict, and at other times because intervention is simply seen as being inconvenient and becomes caught up in international political paralysis.[11]